
Building a reversed Hippo

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HW-01 - White reaches the familiar two-rank formation while Black occupies the center. This quiet illustrative route is not a claim that all ten setup moves are best in every position.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Resolve king safety and choose c4, d4 or e4 as a central challenge. Identify which bishop will become active after the chosen break.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

Black has more space and can prepare ...e4 or ...d4. White's extra tempo has not prevented a central bind.

RECOGNITION TEST

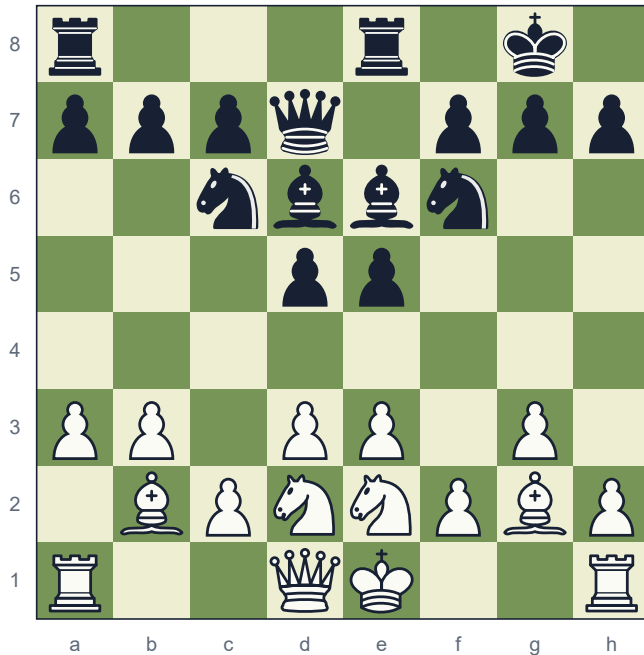
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HW-01 / The complete formation as a study position

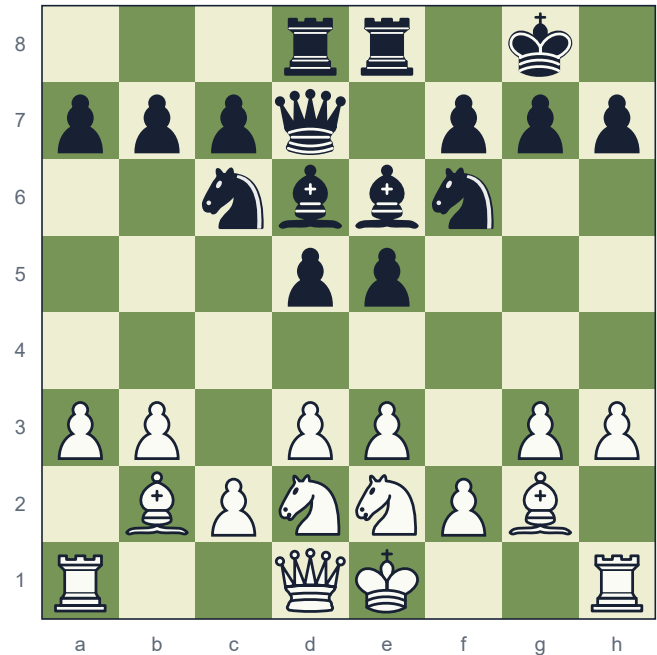
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. e3 Nf6 5. b3 Bd6 6. Bb2 O-O 7. Nd2 Re8 8. Ne2 Be6 9. a3 Qd7 10. h3 Rad8

The anchor is the complete printed sequence.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White reaches the familiar two-rank formation while Black occupies the center. This quiet illustrative route is not a claim that all ten setup moves are best in every position.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Resolve king safety and choose c4, d4 or e4 as a central challenge. Identify which bishop will become active after the chosen break.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black has more space and can prepare ...e4 or ...d4. White's extra tempo has not prevented a central bind.

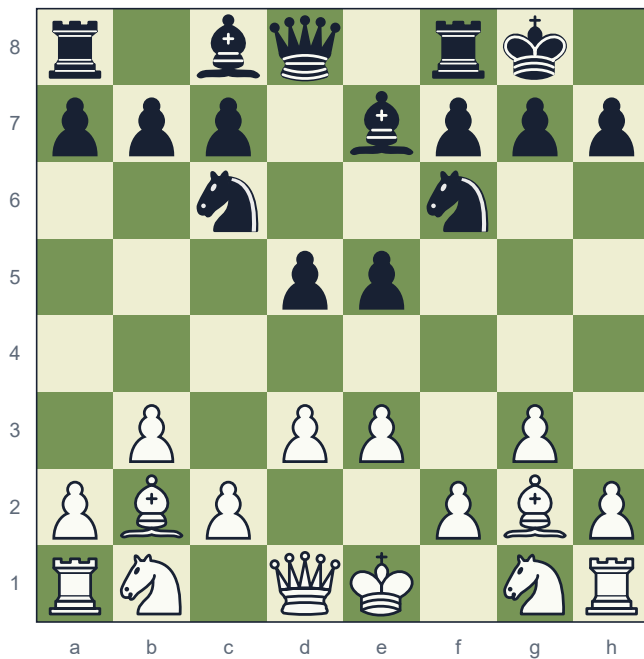
REMEMBER Completing a formation is not the same as gaining an advantage.

HW-02 / Black develops Be7

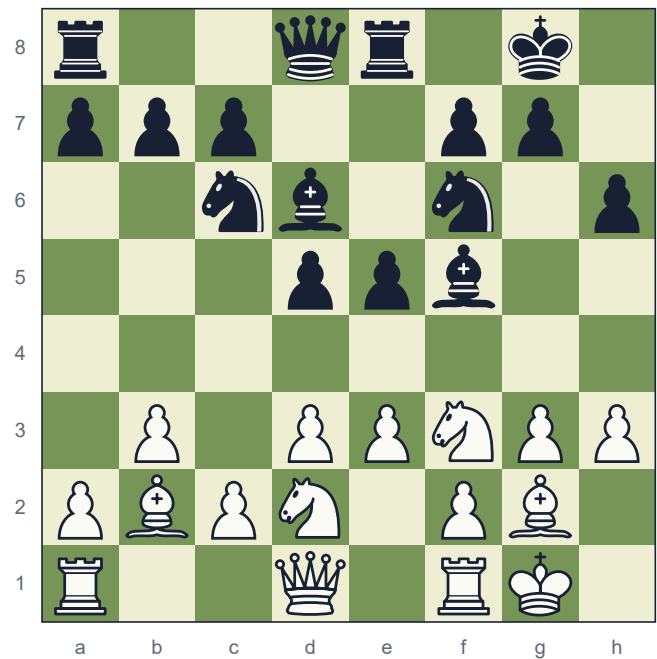
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 Be7 5. b3 O-O 6. Bb2 Nc6 7. Nd2 Re8 8. h3 Bd6 9. Ngf3 h6 10. O-O Bf5

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops modestly and keeps the center intact. White preserves flexibility while the bishops watch long diagonals.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Choose Ne2 or Ngf3 according to the desired break, then castle when safe. c4 can question d5 without first building a large center.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may use ...Re8 and ...Bf8 to prepare central expansion. Quiet development can support a serious squeeze.

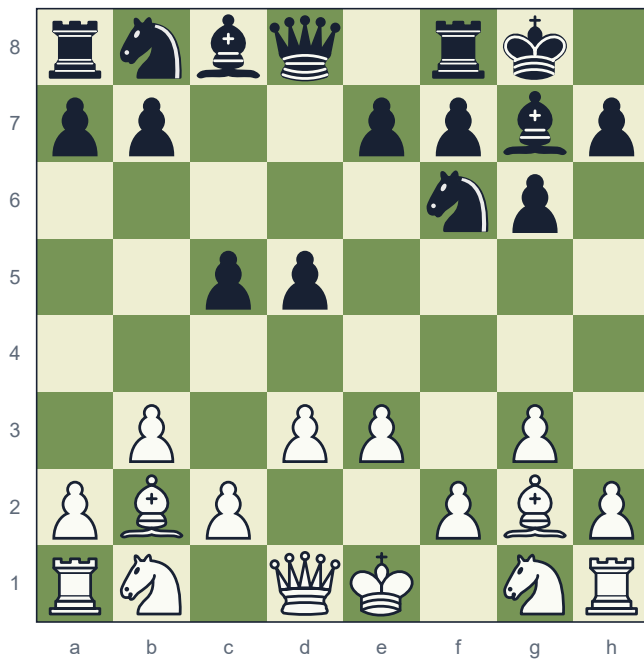
REMEMBER Use flexibility to choose a break, not to postpone every decision.

HW-03 / Black fianchettoes

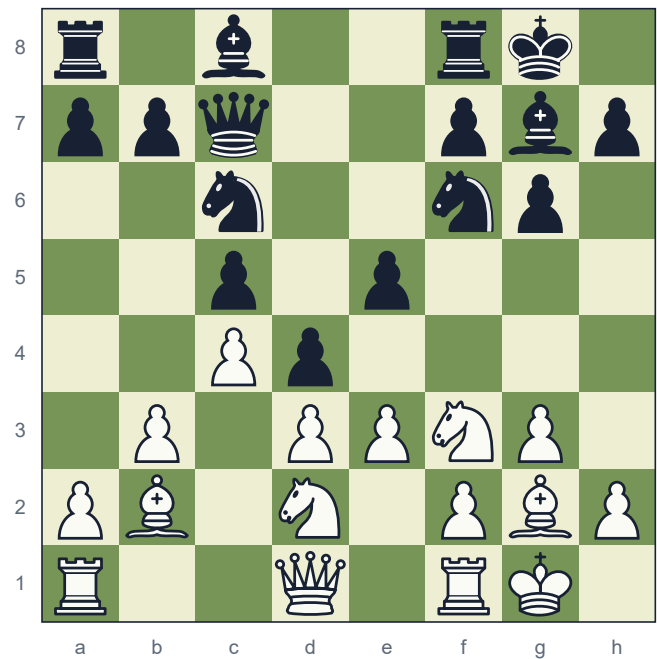
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 Nf6 3. d3 g6 4. e3 Bg7 5. b3 O-O 6. Bb2 c5 7. Nd2 Qc7 8. Ngf3 Nc6 9. O-O e5 10. c4 d4

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black combines central space with a fianchetto. White's b2 bishop points toward the opposing king side, but central pawns may block its influence.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and decide whether c4 or e4 best opens your bishops. Count the pressure on b2 after the center clears.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can advance ...d4 and restrict the b1 knight. The g7 bishop may become stronger than its white counterpart after exchanges.

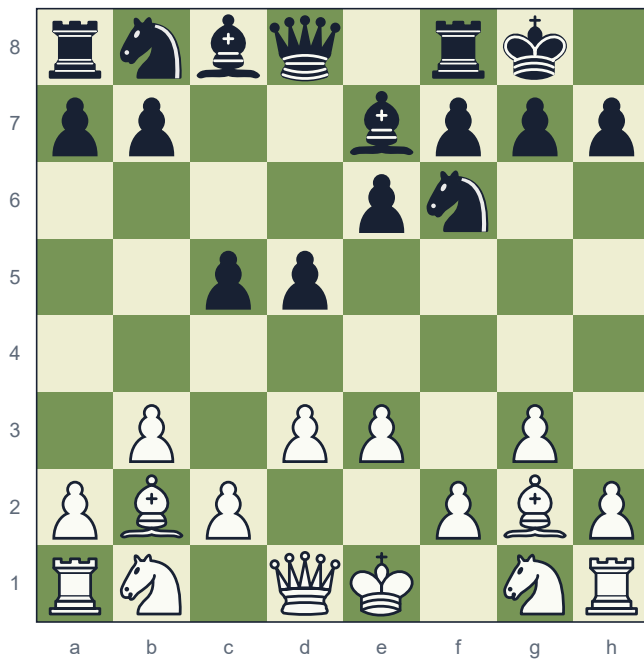
REMEMBER Open the diagonal that helps your pieces most.

HW-04 / Black uses ...e6 and ...d5

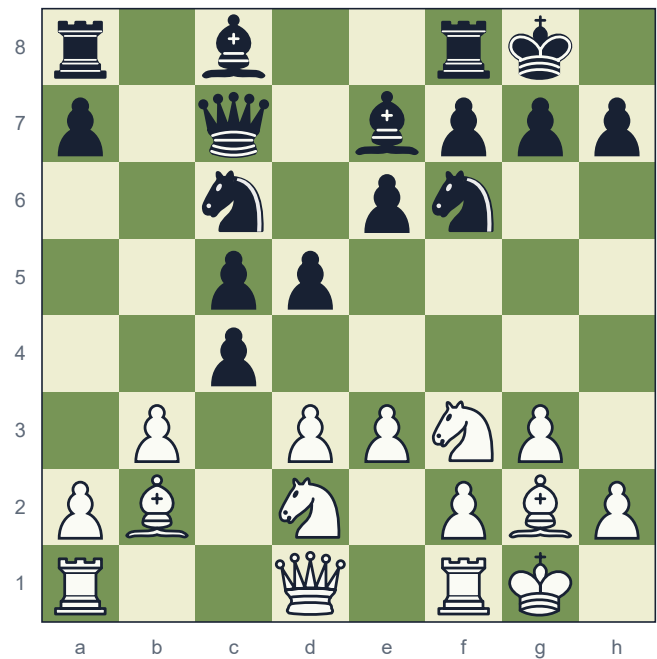
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e6 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 Be7 5. b3 O-O 6. Bb2 c5 7. Nd2 Nc6 8. Ngf3 b5 9. O-O Qc7 10. c4 bxc4

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black has a stable d5-e6 center but has not occupied e5. White has time to prepare a direct central challenge.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Consider Ngf3 and e4, or Ne2 and c4. Choose one coherent route rather than moving both knights repeatedly without a central goal.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

...Nc6 and ...e5 can gain more space. Do not wait for Black to complete every central ambition before responding.

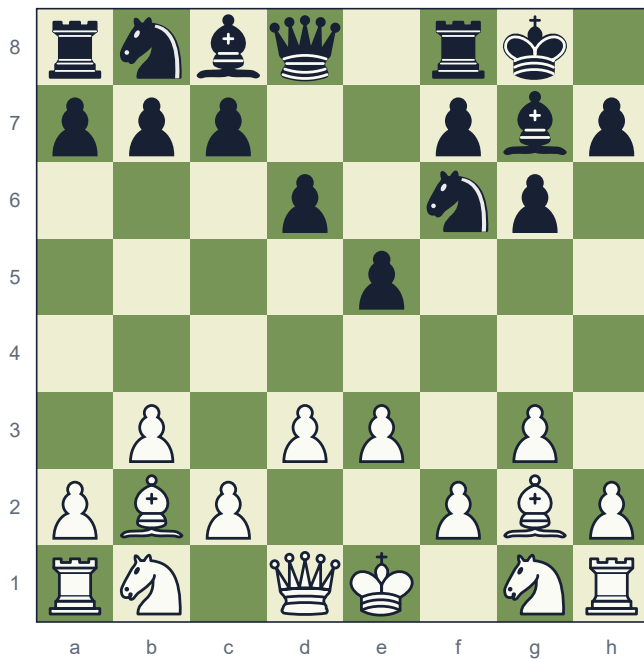
REMEMBER A restrained opponent still needs to be challenged.

HW-05 / Black chooses a ...d6 ...e5 center

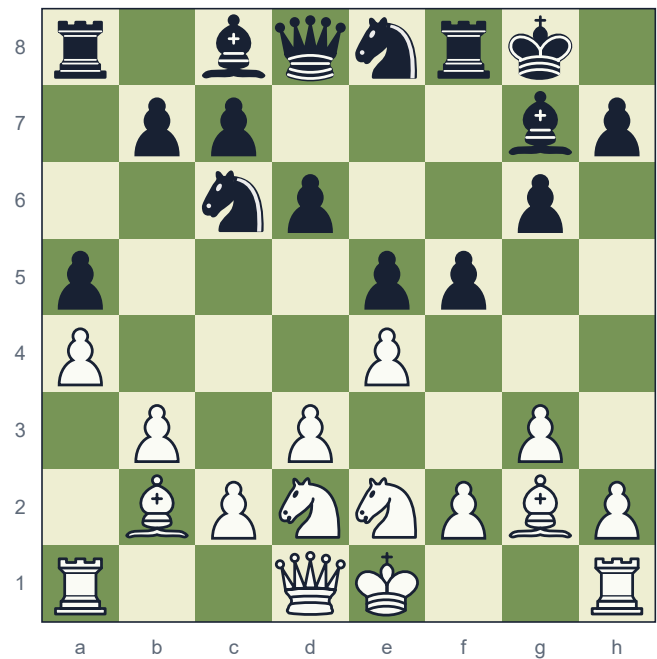
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 e5 2. Bg2 d6 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 g6 5. b3 Bg7 6. Bb2 O-O 7. Nd2 a5 8. a4 Nc6 9. e4 Ne8 10. Ne2 f5

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black's d6 pawn supports e5 and keeps the center flexible. White can choose a partial Hippo or a more active King's Indian Attack structure.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare e4 with c4 and develop the king knight to support that choice. Decide whether the b2 bishop has useful pressure before exchanging e-pawns.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can use ...Nc6 and ...Be6 to develop with central influence. A later ...d5 may seize the initiative if White waits too long.

REMEMBER Watch the break the supporting pawn can eventually make.

HW-06 / Black also plays a Hippo

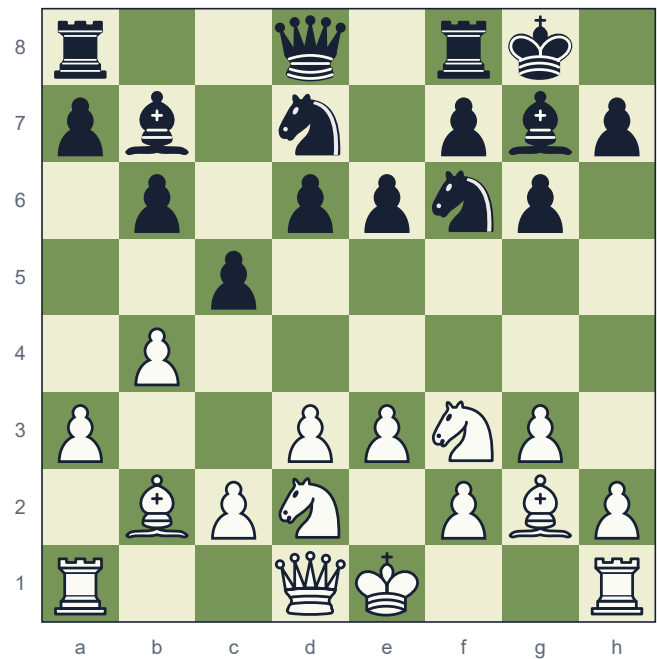
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 g6 2. Bg2 Bg7 3. d3 d6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. e3 e6 6. b3 b6 7. Bb2 Bb7 8. Nbd2 Nbd7 9. b4 c5 10. a3 O-O

Authored anchor ends after 8... Nbd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Both sides restrain the center, but the knights on f3 and f6 block the opposing fianchetto diagonals before b-pawn moves expose the corner rooks. This detail prevents a tactical accident.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use the first move to develop and choose a central claim such as e4 or c4. Castling may be more valuable than automatically adding a3 and h3.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Without a blocker on the long diagonal, b3 or ...b6 can expose a corner rook to the enemy bishop. Never build this formation without tracing the diagonal.

REMEMBER Block the long diagonal before exposing the corner rook.

Work through HW-01

7. ND2

Develops a knight to support e4 and leave the c-pawn flexible. Check that it does not unnecessarily obstruct the queen bishop.

8. NE2

Develops the king knight without fixing the f-pawn. Compare its onward route with the immediate central influence of Nf3.

9. A3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

10. H3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White reaches the familiar two-rank formation while Black occupies the center. This quiet illustrative route is not a claim that all ten setup moves are best in every position. Resolve king safety and choose c4, d4 or e4 as a central challenge. Identify which bishop will become active after the chosen break.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Responding to central space

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HW-07 - Black establishes c5-d5-e5. White must challenge the center before completing every wing pawn move.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop a knight to support c4 or e4, and calculate the resulting exchanges. Consider whether a partial formation gives more active play than the complete shell.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

...d4 can close the center with a large space advantage. If every white piece lacks squares, the setup has become too slow.

RECOGNITION TEST

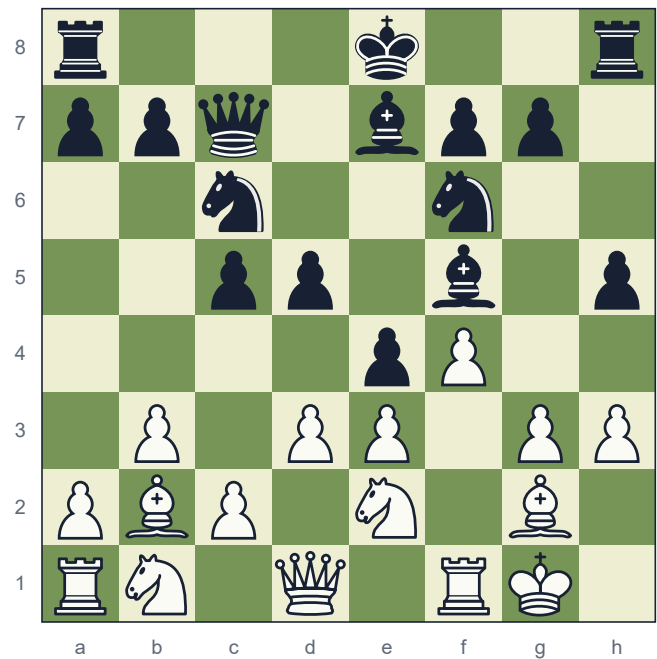
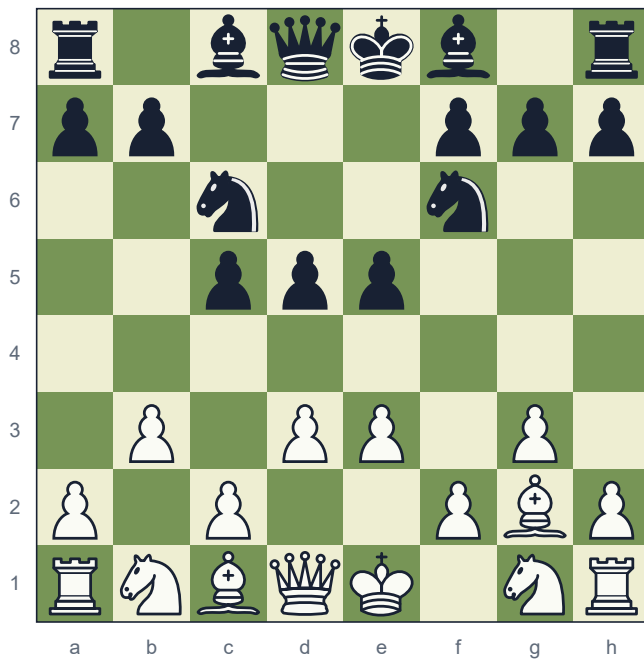
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HW-07 / Black grabs space with ...c5

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 c5 4. e3 Nc6 5. b3 Nf6 6. Bb2 Be7 7. Ne2 h5 8. h3 Qc7 9. O-O Bf5 10. f4 e4

Authored anchor ends after 6... Be7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Black establishes c5-d5-e5. White must challenge the center before completing every wing pawn move.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop a knight to support c4 or e4, and calculate the resulting exchanges. Consider whether a partial formation gives more active play than the complete shell.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

...d4 can close the center with a large space advantage. If every white piece lacks squares, the setup has become too slow.

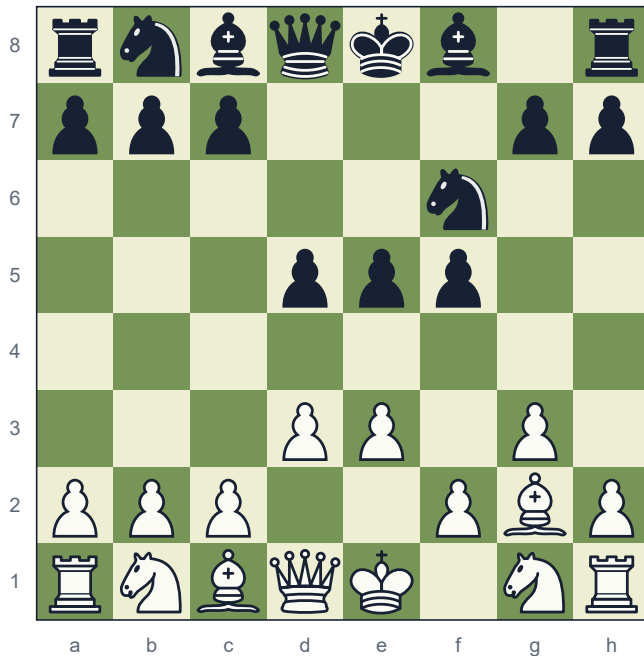
REMEMBER A three-pawn center calls for a timely lever.

HW-08 / Black adds ...f5

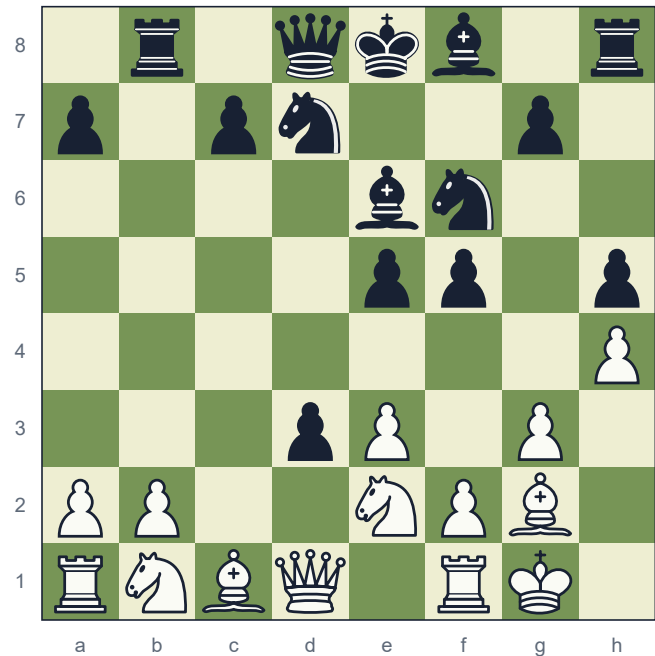
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 e5 2. Bg2 d5 3. d3 f5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Ne2 Be6 6. O-O h5 7. c4 dxc4 8. Bxb7 Nbd7 9. h4 Rb8 10. Bg2 cxd3

Authored anchor ends after 5. Ne2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White develops the king knight and prepares king safety against Black's ambitious center. Delaying b3 can be sensible when the center needs urgent attention.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare c4 and f4 only after calculating captures and king exposure. A supported e4 break may also change the central balance.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may push ...e4 or ...f4 with tempo. A slow double fianchetto can become a target if the center opens before White castles.

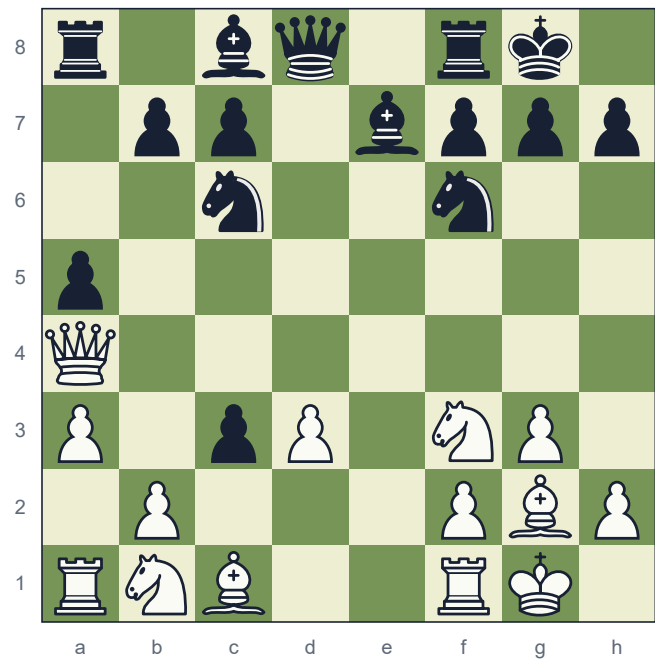
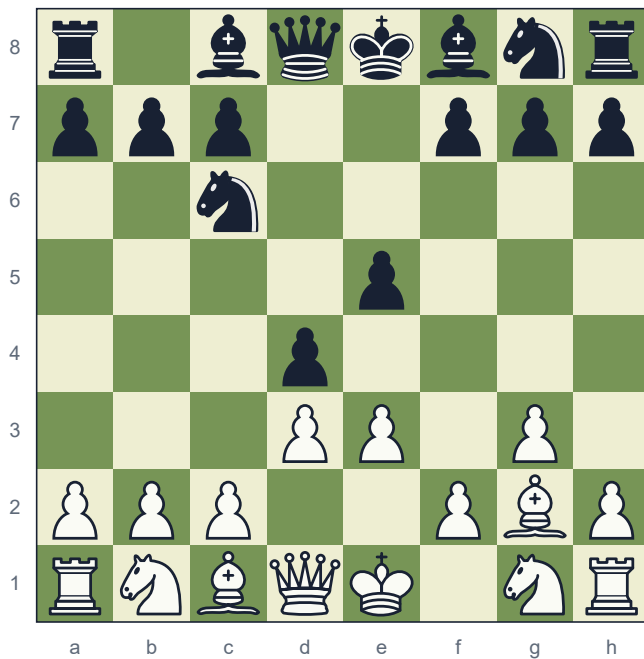
REMEMBER Development comes before decorative symmetry.

HW-09 / Black advances ...d4 early

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. e3 d4 5. exd4 exd4 6. Nf3 Nf6 7. O-O Be7 8. a3 a5 9. c3 O-O 10. Qa4 dxc3

Authored anchor ends after 5... exd4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White exchanges the invading pawn and changes the structure. Black retains a d4 wedge, but White has opened a diagonal and can attack the pawn.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop Ne2 or Nf3 and target d4 with c3 when safe. Decide whether the queen bishop belongs on b2 or a more direct square.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The d4 pawn restricts Nc3 and may support a central outpost. Do not place a knight where an enemy pawn can simply capture it.

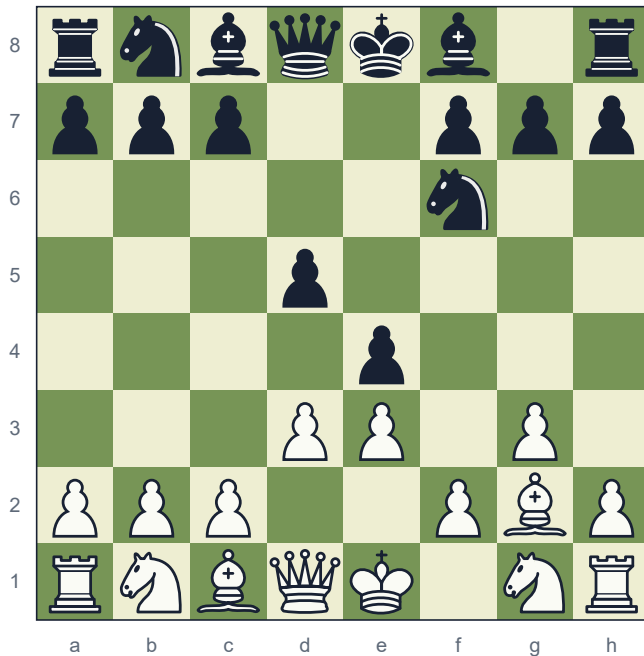
REMEMBER Deal with the wedge before finishing the formation.

HW-10 / Black advances ...e4 early

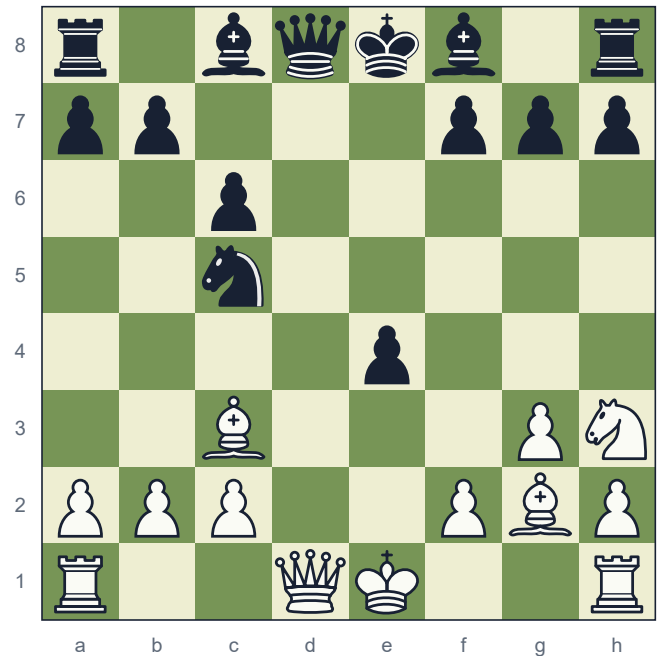
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 e4 5. dxe4 Nxe4 6. Nd2 Nxd2 7. Bxd2 c6 8. Bc3 Nd7 9. e4 dxe4 10. Nh3 Nc5

Authored anchor ends after 5... Nxe4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The central exchange releases Black's knight onto e4. White has prevented a permanent pawn wedge but must now address the active piece.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop with pressure on e4 and keep the queen and king safe along opened files. Choose a knight square that helps challenge the outpost.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A central knight can threaten forks on c3 or f2 depending on the position. Check its concrete attacks before making another pawn move.

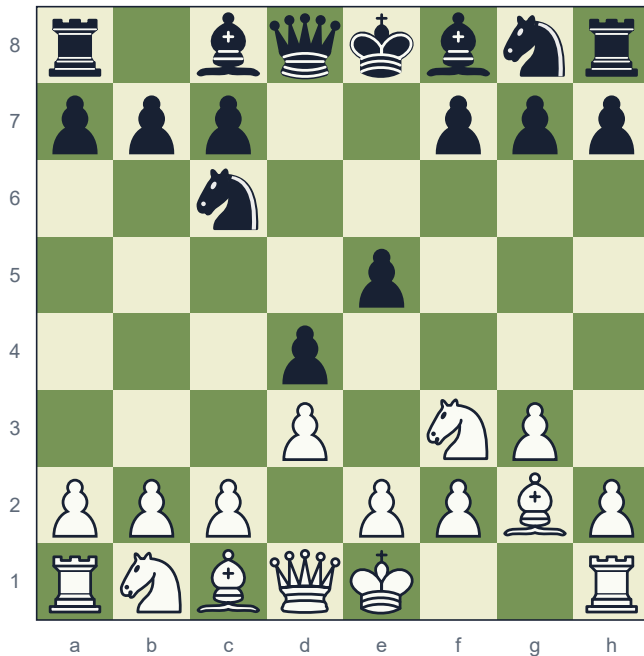
REMEMBER Exchanging a pawn can replace it with a stronger piece.

HW-11 / Black plays ...d4 before e3

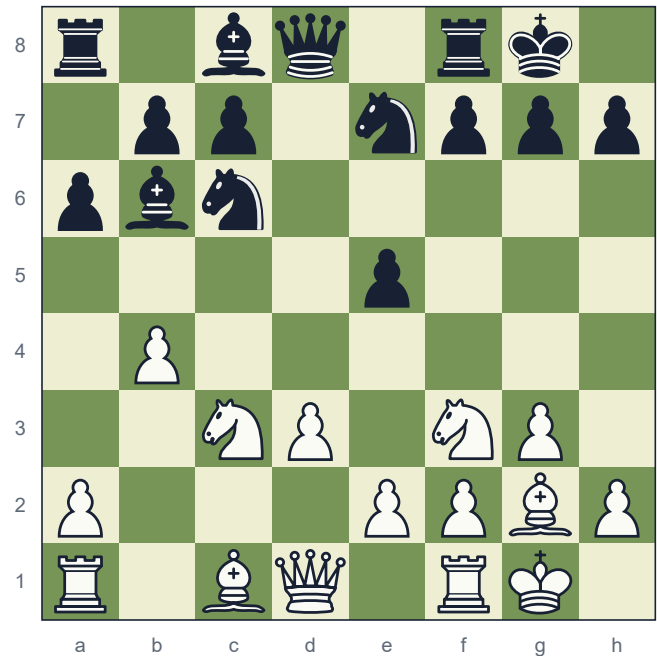
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. O-O Bc5 6. Nbd2 Nge7 7. Ne4 Bb6 8. b4 a6 9. c3 dxc3 10. Nxc3 O-O

Authored anchor ends after 5. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White abandons the strict Ne2 formation and develops quickly against Black's space. Nf3 is a practical adaptation when central pressure matters more than symmetry.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Use e3 or c3 to undermine d4, and bring out the queen knight to support the chosen break.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can consolidate with ...Nf6 and ...Be7. Further waiting can let the d4 pawn become a permanent restriction.

REMEMBER Use the knight square the position needs.

HW-12 / Black plays an early ...c6

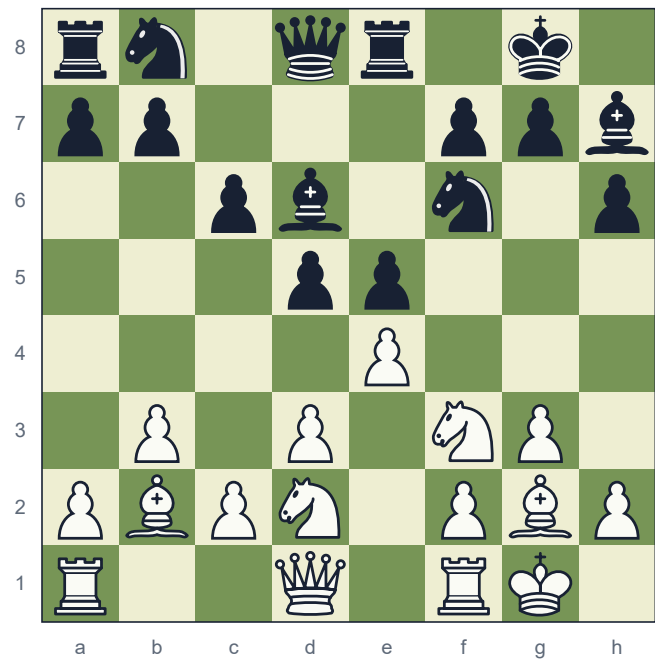
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 c6 3. d3 e5 4. e3 Nf6 5. b3 Bd6 6. Bb2 O-O 7. Nd2 Re8 8. Ngf3 h6 9. O-O Bf5 10. e4 Bh7

Authored anchor ends after 6. Bb2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black supports d5 and may expand with ...e4. White's b2 bishop puts indirect pressure on e5, but that pressure depends on the central pawn contacts.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop a knight and calculate c4 as a challenge to d5. Complete king safety before opening the center widely.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

...e4 can gain space and attack useful squares. Do not count a bishop as attacking through your own e3 pawn.

REMEMBER A blocked diagonal is potential, not present pressure.

Work through HW-07

7. NE2

Develops the king knight without fixing the f-pawn. Compare its onward route with the immediate central influence of Nf3.

8. H3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

9. O-O

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

10. F4

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black establishes c5-d5-e5. White must challenge the center before completing every wing pawn move. Develop a knight to support c4 or e4, and calculate the resulting exchanges. Consider whether a partial formation gives more active play than the complete shell.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Flank attacks and early tactics

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HW-13 - Black attacks the g3 pawn before building a center. Nf3 develops and can capture on h4 when Black advances without support.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Return the knight to a useful square if attacked and complete development. Accepting a pawn is useful only if it does not cost excessive time or king safety.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

Black may strike in the center while the knight sits on the rim. Do not keep chasing pawns instead of developing.

RECOGNITION TEST

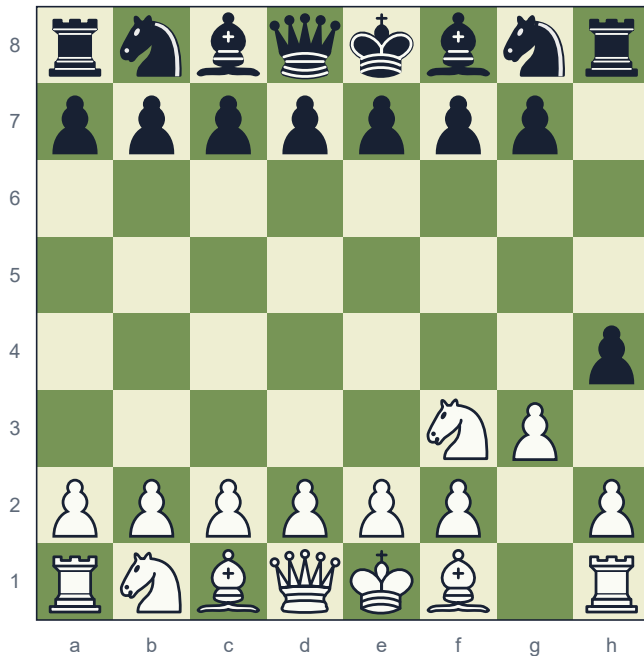
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HW-13 / An immediate ...h5

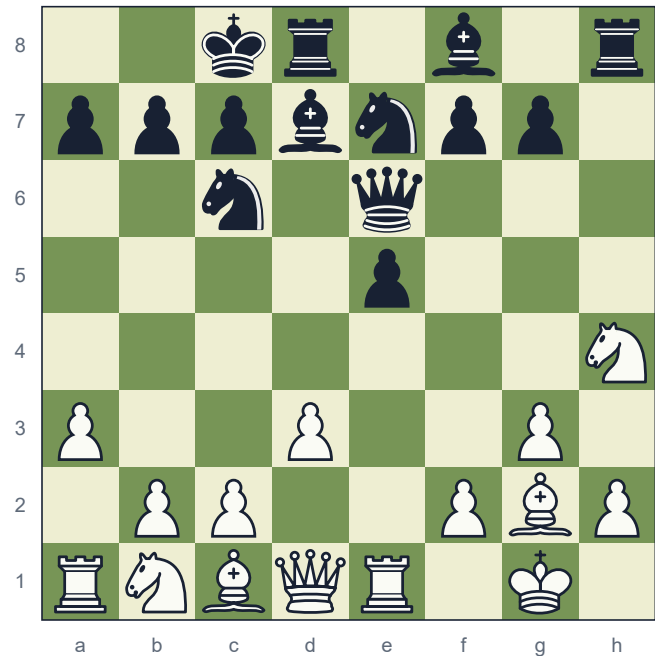
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 h5 2. Nf3 h4 3. Nxh4 e5 4. e4 Nc6 5. d3 d5 6. exd5 Qxd5 7. Bg2 Qe6 8. a3 Bd7 9. O-O O-O-O 10. Re1 Nge7

Authored anchor ends after 3. Nxh4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black attacks the g3 pawn before building a center. Nf3 develops and can capture on h4 when Black advances without support.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Return the knight to a useful square if attacked and complete development. Accepting a pawn is useful only if it does not cost excessive time or king safety.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black may strike in the center while the knight sits on the rim. Do not keep chasing pawns instead of developing.

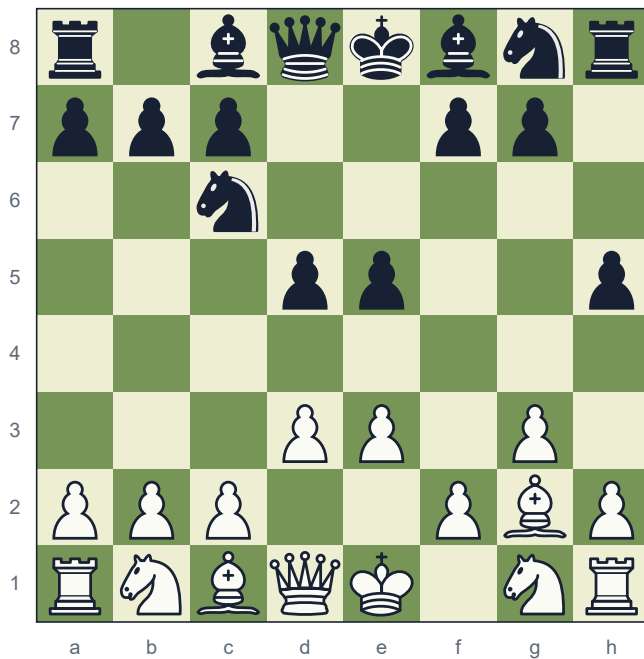
REMEMBER A premature flank attack may be met by a developing move.

HW-14 / The supported h-pawn attack

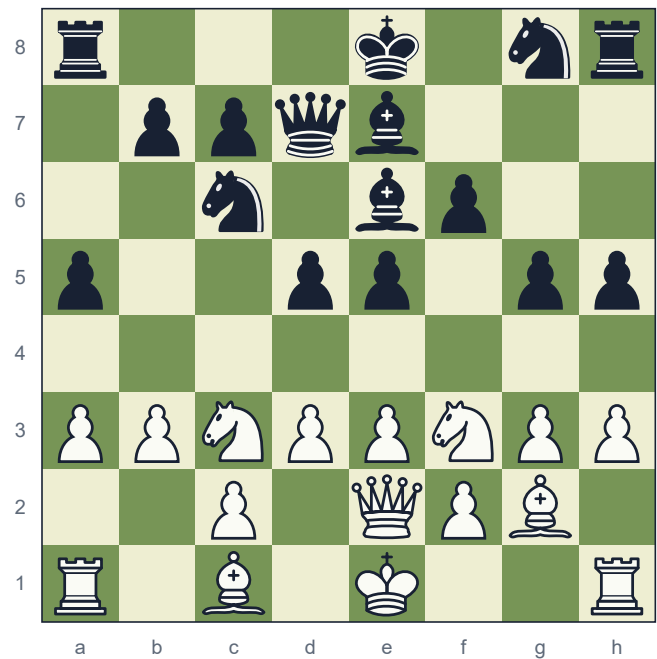
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. e3 h5 5. h3 Be6 6. a3 a5 7. Nc3 Qd7 8. b3 Be7 9. Nf3 f6 10. Qe2 g5

Authored anchor ends after 5. h3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White restrains ...h4 by preparing to meet the pawn contact on favorable terms. This is a specific defensive decision, not a requirement to play h3 in every Hippo.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop quickly and consider central counterplay. If ...h4 arrives, calculate gxh4 and exchanges rather than assuming the wing is locked.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can prepare ...g5 or castle long. A pawn on h3 can become a hook if the rest of the position is neglected.

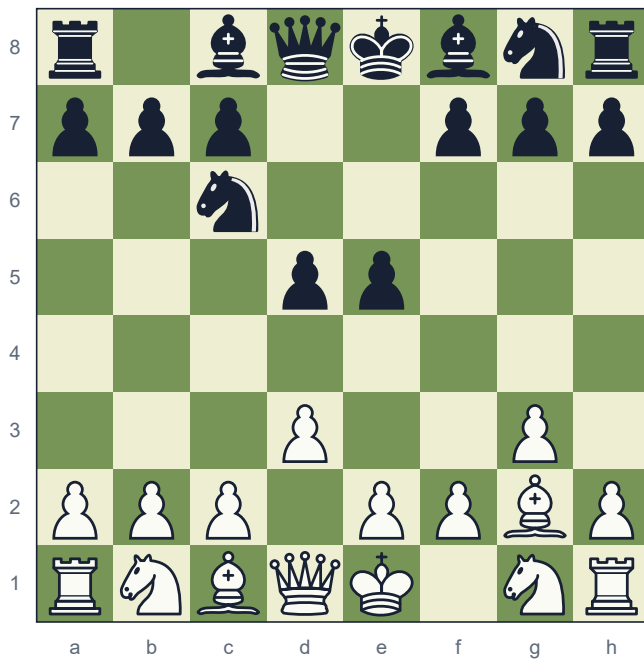
REMEMBER A defensive pawn move creates a future target too.

HW-15 / The ...g5 expansion

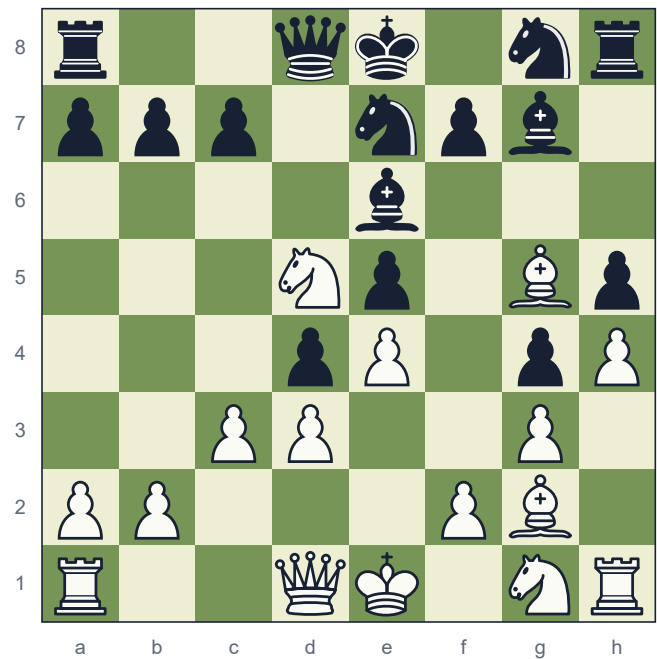
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. e3 g5 5. Nc3 Be6 6. e4 d4 7. Nd5 h5 8. h4 g4 9. c3 Nce7 10. Bg5 Bg7

Authored anchor ends after 4... g5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black gains kingside space while delaying development. White should look for central action and king safety rather than merely copying a pawn wall.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Examine c4 or h4 concretely and develop knights. Choose the king's destination after assessing whether the g- and h-files may open.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can play ...h5-h4 and gain attacking tempi. A passive reply may turn a premature advance into a strong attack.

REMEMBER Test a wing expansion before it becomes supported.

HW-16 / An early ...Bh3 attempt

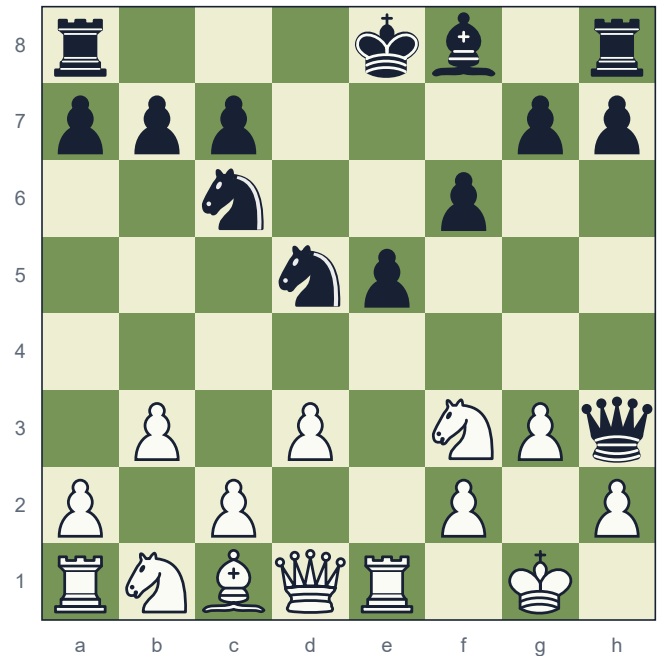
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. Nf3 Be6 5. O-O Qd7 6. b3 Bh3 7. Bxh3 Qxh3 8. e4 Nf6 9. exd5 Nxd5 10. Re1 f6

Authored anchor ends after 7... Qxh3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black exchanges the g2 bishop and brings the queen toward White's already castled king. White's knight has left g1, so the queen on h3 cannot simply be captured by that knight.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Inspect checks and dark-square threats, develop with tempo if available and look for central counterplay. The king is already on g1, so the task is defending the actual shelter.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

If White's knight were still on g1, ...Qxh3 would lose the queen to Nxh3. In this line its different square makes the attack a real concern.

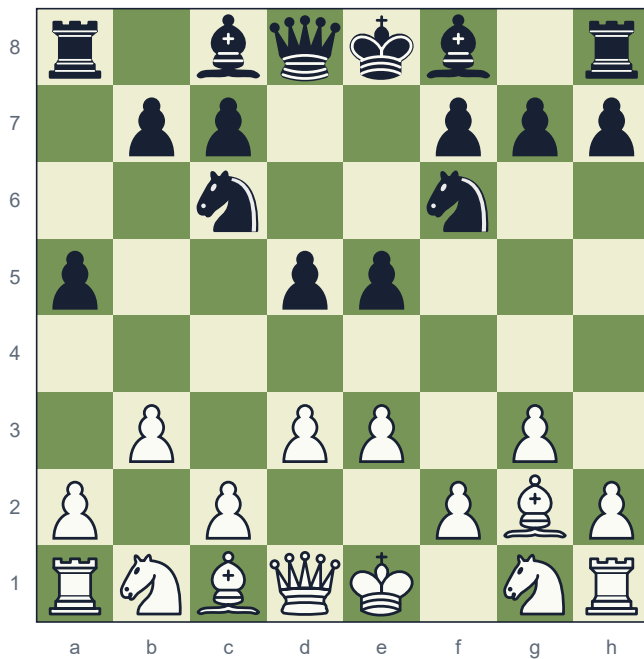
REMEMBER A queen recapture depends on the knight's exact square.

HW-17 / Queenside expansion with ...a5

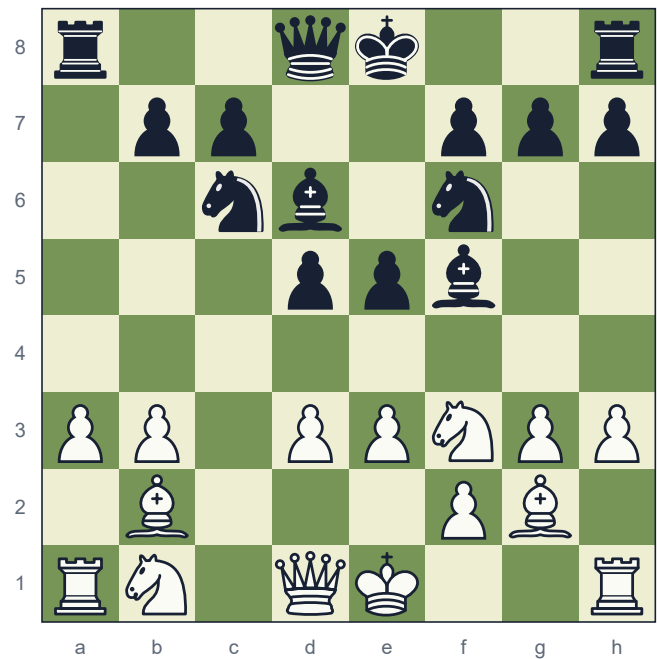
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nc6 4. e3 Nf6 5. b3 a5 6. Bb2 a4 7. a3 axb3 8. cxb3 Bg4 9. Nf3 Bd6 10. h3 Bf5

Authored anchor ends after 6... a4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black attacks the b3 structure and seeks open queenside lines. White must calculate the pawn contact before adding a routine knight move.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare bxa4 with a3 and central counterplay, including rook files and bishop activity after the exchanges.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

The b2 bishop and a1 rook can become targets when files open. A queenside attack may matter even if your king plans to castle short.

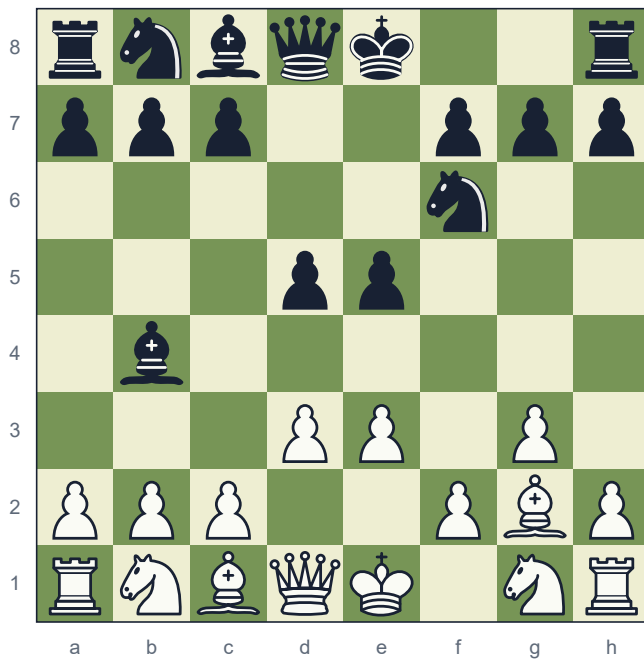
REMEMBER Defend pieces behind the pawn contact.

HW-18 / Black develops ...Bb4+

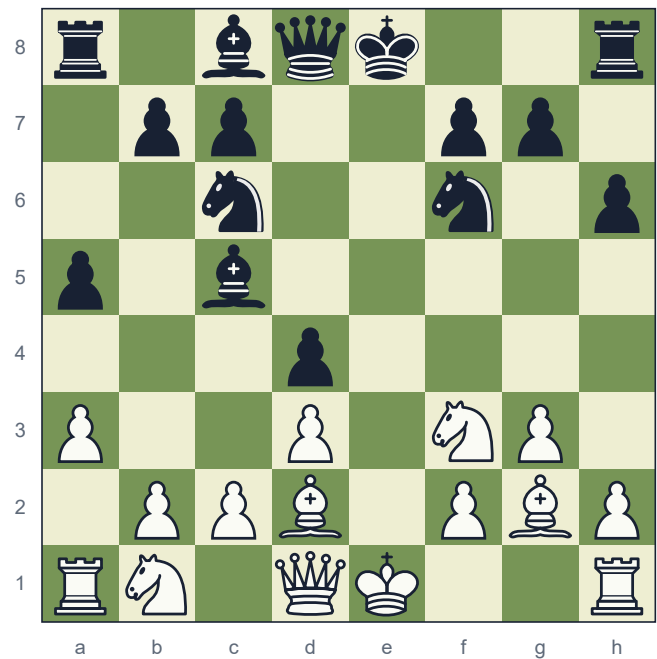
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 e5 2. Bg2 d5 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 Bb4+ 5. Bd2 a5 6. a3 Bc5 7. Nf3 Nc6 8. Bc3 d4 9. exd4 exd4 10. Bd2 h6

Authored anchor ends after 5. Bd2. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The bishop check interrupts the setup. Bd2 develops while blocking; the queen bishop does not have to reach b2 in every game.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and decide whether a later bishop exchange improves coordination. Keep the central pawns supported and castle when safe.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Moving a pawn to block without checking the resulting weaknesses may cost time. A fixed formation is no reason to choose an inferior response to check.

REMEMBER Respond to the check with the best developing move.

Work through HW-13

7. BG2

Places the bishop on g2, attacking queen on d5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

8. A3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

9. O-O

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

10. RE1

Places the rook on the e-file, commonly supporting e4 or preparing pressure against an opposing king or central pawn.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black attacks the g3 pawn before building a center. Nf3 develops and can capture on h4 when Black advances without support. Return the knight to a useful square if attacked and complete development. Accepting a pawn is useful only if it does not cost excessive time or king safety.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Useful departures from the complete formation

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HW-19 - White challenges d5 with active development and a castled king. This useful departure resembles a Reti or reversed King's Indian structure more than a complete Hippo.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Compare ...d4, ...dxc4 and maintaining tension. Develop the queen side according to the resulting pawn structure.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

If Black closes with ...d4, Nc3 may be restricted. Plan the knight route before fixing every pawn.

RECOGNITION TEST

For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HW-19 / Choose c4 before the complete shell

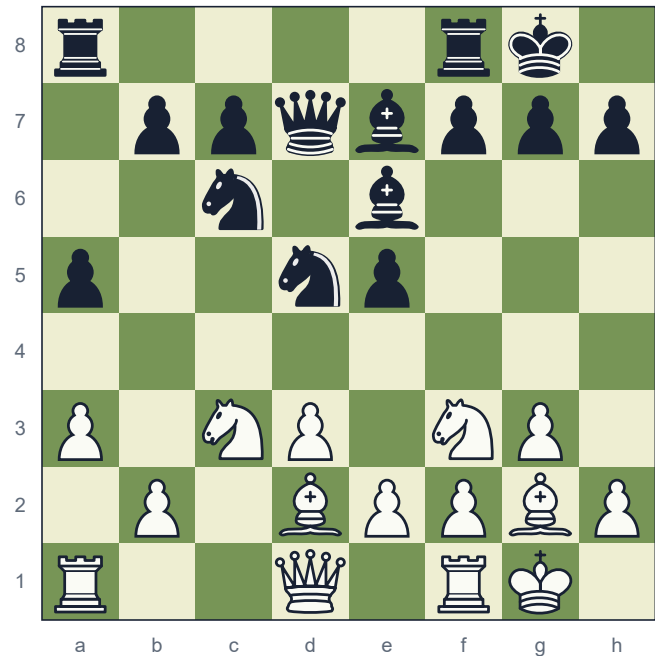
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 e5 3. d3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. O-O Be7 6. c4 O-O 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Nc3 Be6 9. Bd2 Qd7 10. a3 a5

Authored anchor ends after 6. c4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White challenges d5 with active development and a castled king. This useful departure resembles a Reti or reversed King's Indian structure more than a complete Hippo.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare ...d4, ...dxc4 and maintaining tension. Develop the queen side according to the resulting pawn structure.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

If Black closes with ...d4, Nc3 may be restricted. Plan the knight route before fixing every pawn.

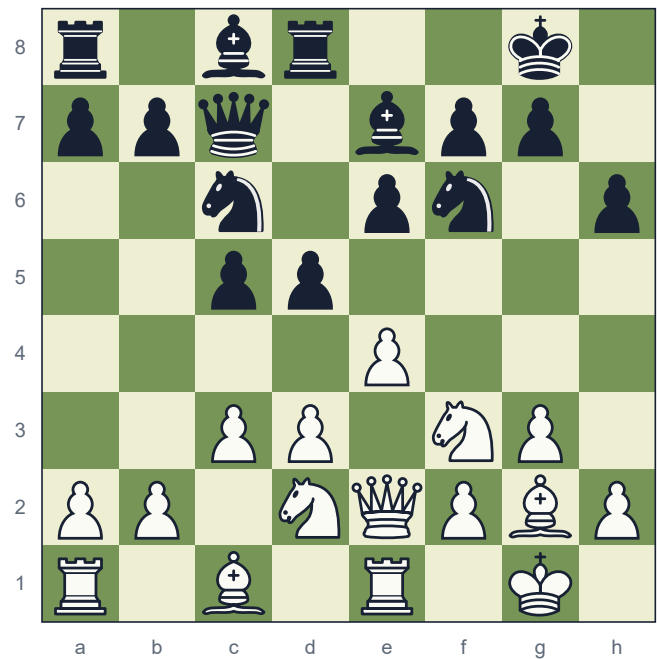
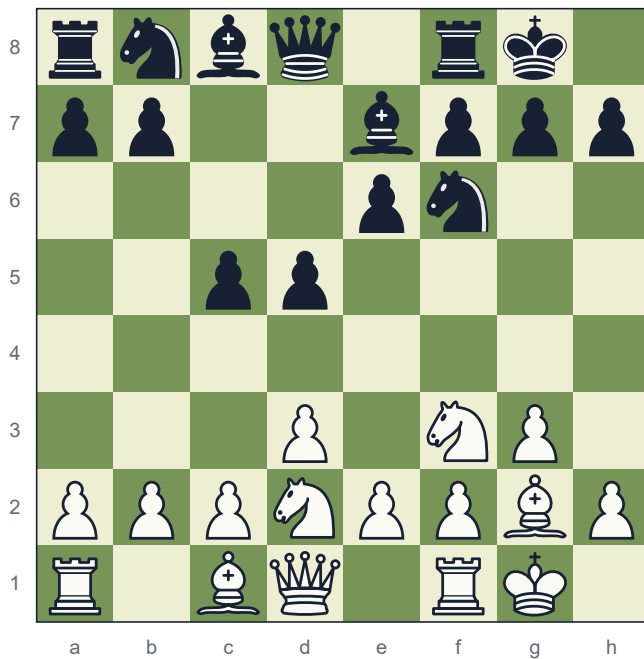
REMEMBER The best Hippo lesson may be when to leave it.

HW-20 / Choose e4 for a KIA transition

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 d5 2. Bg2 Nf6 3. d3 e6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. O-O O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1 Qc7 9. c3 h6 10. Qe2 Rd8

Authored anchor ends after 7. e4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White adopts a King's Indian Attack center because Black's structure makes it useful. The b-pawn remains flexible instead of being committed automatically.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Support e4, then assess e5 and the available knight routes. Use the KIA course for deeper study of this exact center.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can exchange on e4 or advance ...d4. Do not assume the e5 attack is available in every branch.

REMEMBER Transition by pawn structure, not by a preferred name.

HW-21 / Choose d4 against a restrained center

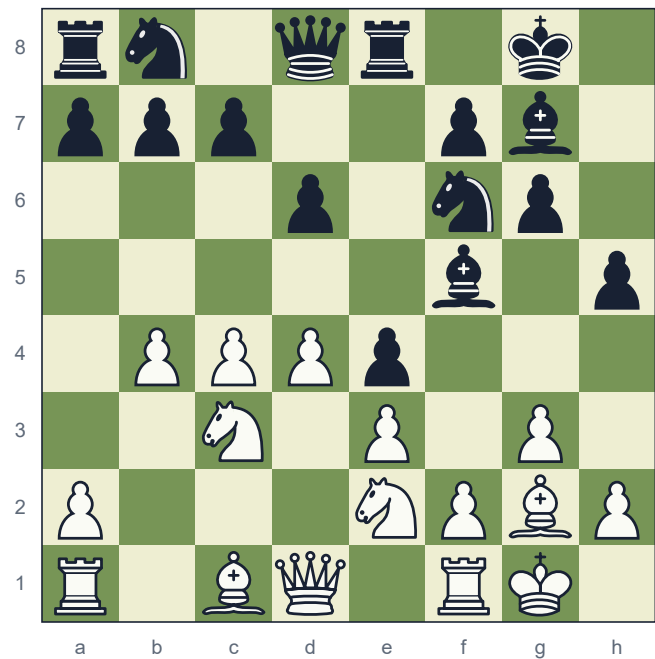
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 g6 2. Bg2 Bg7 3. d3 d6 4. e3 Nf6 5. Ne2 O-O 6. O-O e5 7. d4 e4 8. b4 Re8 9. c4 h5 10. Nbc3 Bf5

Authored anchor ends after 7. d4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White uses development and king safety to justify a central claim. The d-pawn advances only after the pieces are ready to cope with exchanges.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Calculate ...exd4 and ...Nc6, then develop the queen side to useful squares. Compare the activity of the g2 bishop after the center opens.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Advancing d4 may leave e3 weak or open lines for Black too. A central gain is not free of structural consequences.

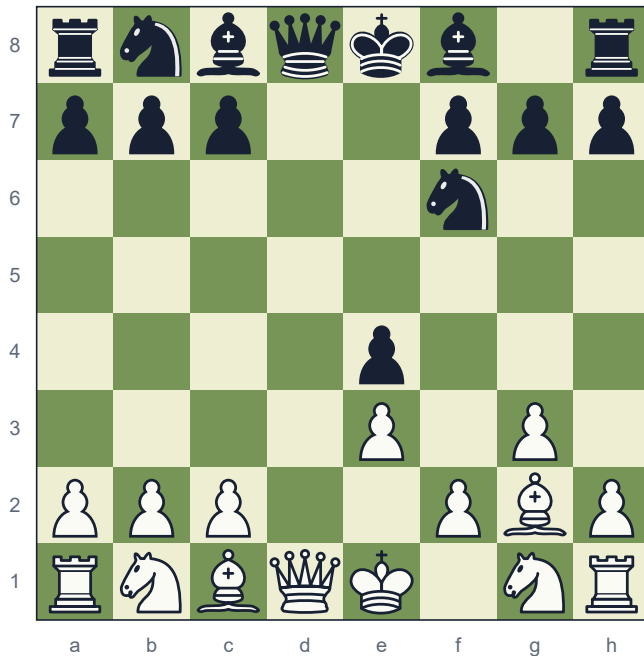
REMEMBER Take central space when your pieces can support it.

HW-22 / Trade queens when the file opens

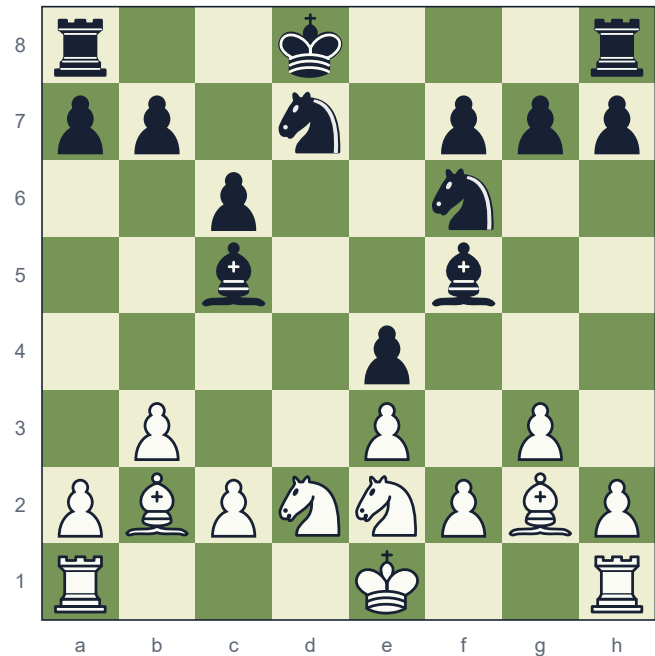
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 e5 2. Bg2 d5 3. d3 Nf6 4. e3 e4 5. dxe4 dxe4 6. Qxd8+ Kxd8 7. Ne2 Bf5 8. Nd2 Bc5 9. b3 Nbd7 10. Bb2 c6

Authored anchor ends after 6... Kxd8. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The exchanges open the d-file and allow White to remove queens. Black loses castling rights, but with queens gone the main issue is piece activity and pawn targets.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the knights, assess the e4 pawn and activate the king when safe. Do not keep playing for a direct king attack without queens.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black's centralized king may become useful if the position simplifies further. A lost castling right alone does not prove an advantage.

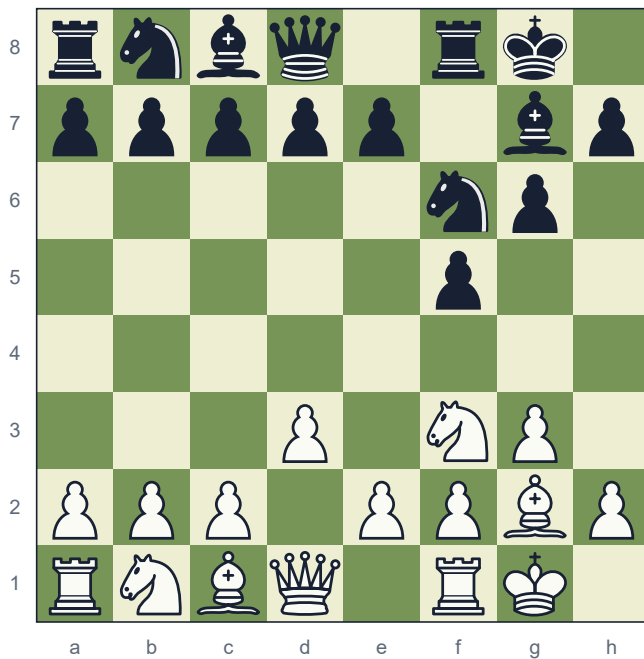
REMEMBER Evaluate the position after the queens disappear.

HW-23 / Use Nf3 against a Dutch center

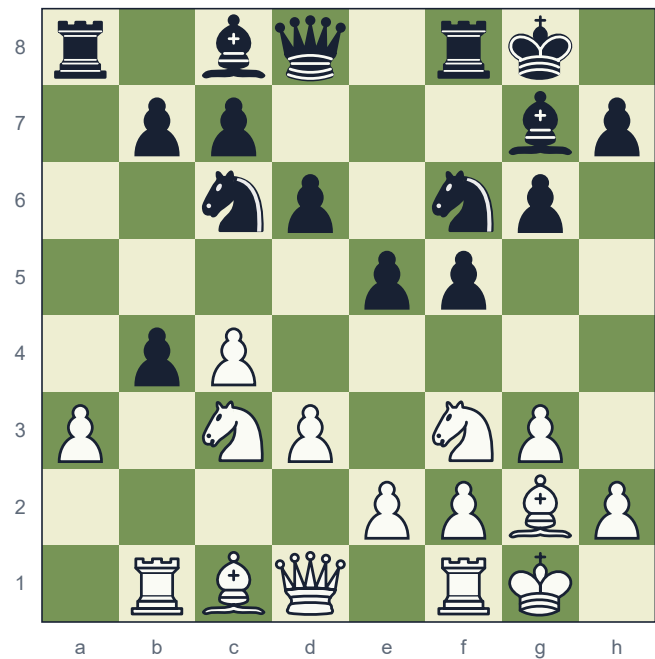
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 f5 2. Bg2 Nf6 3. d3 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. O-O O-O 6. c4 d6 7. Nc3 Nc6 8. Rb1 a5 9. a3 e5 10. b4 axb4

Authored anchor ends after 6. c4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White develops actively and challenges the center with c4 rather than waiting for a full double fianchetto. Black's f-pawn commitment helps define the dark-square battle.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Prepare Nc3 and e4 if justified, or contest d5 directly. Keep an eye on the g7 bishop and Black's potential ...e5 break.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Black can build a strong kingside attack if given too much time. Do not answer every threat with a small pawn move.

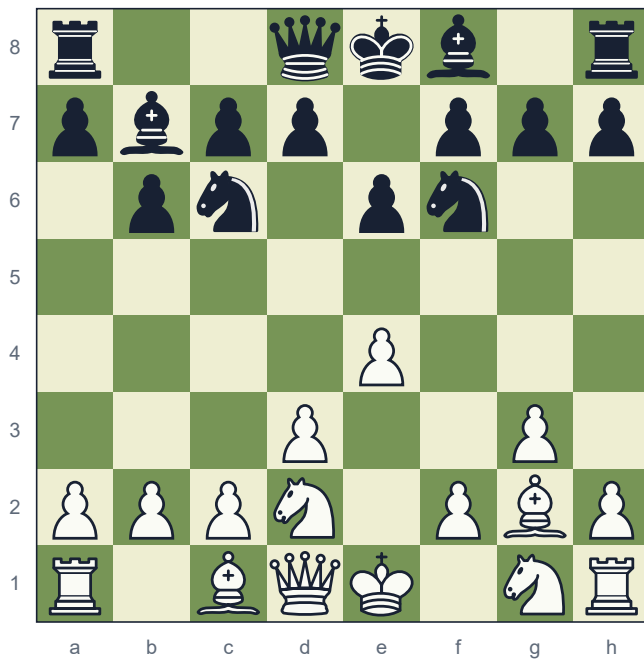
REMEMBER Choose active development when the opponent has a clear attack.

HW-24 / Against early ...b6: occupy the center

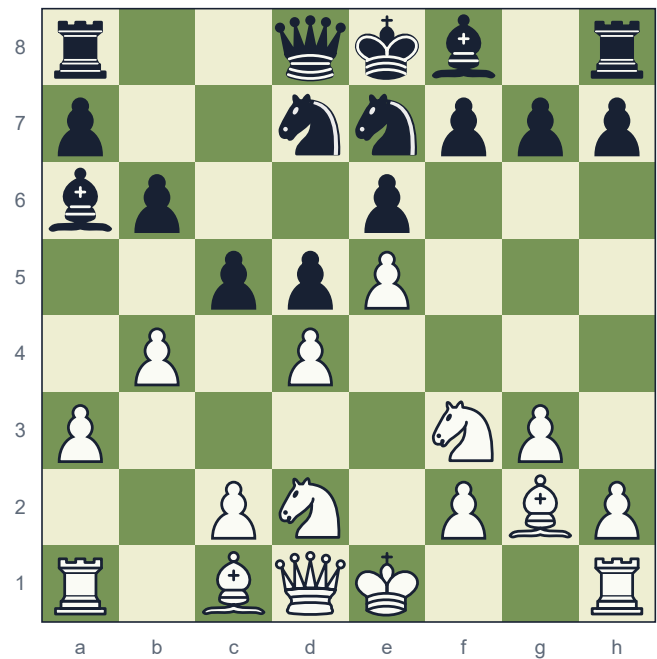
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. g3 b6 2. Bg2 Nc6 3. e4 Bb7 4. d3 e6 5. Nd2 Nf6 6. Ngf3 d5 7. e5 Nd7 8. d4 Ba6 9. a3 Ne7 10. b4 c5

Authored anchor ends after 6. Ngf3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black blocks the g2-b7 diagonal with Nc6 before putting the bishop on b7. White uses the flank development to establish a central foothold.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Castle, support e4 and compare central exchanges. The position may become a KIA-style game rather than a complete Hippo.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Immediate ...Bb7 without a blocker would leave that bishop available to Bxb7. Check the long diagonal before assuming a normal fianchetto is safe.

REMEMBER Use central space and inspect undefended fianchetto bishops.

Work through HW-19

7. CXD5

The pawn captures a pawn on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

8. NC3

Places the knight on c3, attacking knight on d5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

9. BD2

Places the bishop on d2. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

10. A3

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White challenges d5 with active development and a castled king. This useful departure resembles a Reti or reversed King's Indian structure more than a complete Hippo. Compare ...d4, ...dxc4 and maintaining tension. Develop the queen side according to the resulting pawn structure.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.